

Count Down Under

Playtest record set | GAME 1501 A3, Pitch-Ready Prototype
Sprint cycle 28 July to 17 August 2026 | Group of four

Method

Three observation sessions were run. Two on 10 August 2026, the midpoint of the cycle, and one on 18 August 2026, submission day. Notes were taken on paper at the time and are transcribed below without alteration beyond grouping. The revision attributed to each observation was reconstructed afterwards from the project's commit history, because the original notes were not filed alongside the code and no commit message references a playtest. Where a link could not be established with confidence it is marked as such rather than asserted.

Session 1: Expert review

Date: 10 August 2026 **Observer:** a former instructor of the group **Format:** reviewed build, verbal notes taken by the team

Observation focus: production quality and rendering. This was a review by an experienced developer, not a first-time player session, and the record is treated as expert feedback rather than player behaviour.

Player-behaviour observations

- Did not know that the player had to jump through buildings.
- Dangers read as intentional.

Readability notes

- Reveal that the tunnels are where the player can go.
- Show a light for the tunnel.

Art and implementation notes

- Bat sprite reads well. Vampire spritesheet needs more frames.
- Reorder the player prefab construction for the spritesheet so no `GetComponent` call is required.

Rendering notes

- Post-processing: chromatic aberration plus colour correction.
- Lighting: 2D spot lights with volumetric effects.
- Bloom plus chromatic aberration.
- Move from a box volume to a dedicated volume with colour adjustments.

Session 2: Player observation

Date: 10 August 2026 **Player:** a relative of one team member, no prior exposure to the prototype **Observer:** that team member, taking notes during play

Observation focus: whether a first-time player could read the controls, the objective and the environment without instruction.

What the player understood

- Did not take long to work out the controls and their purposes.
- Understood the environment.
- Navigating over buildings and through the tunnels made sense.

What the player missed

- Did not get the sightseeing objective. The observer sketched a proposed HUD counter reading “sights to see 1/3” in the upper left of the screen, alongside two further screen mockups bracketed and labelled Animation / VFX.

Bugs and feel

- Dashing through lights.
- Movement continues sometimes.
- Got caught on the crocodile.
- Clock not working.
- Flight not always working.
- Analogue controls: delay in directional change.
- Flying is mechanically diverse but not yet tight. Could be tighter.

Difficulty and design

- Hard to die. May need to be more difficult.
- The alligator jump is confusing. The lunge attack may be on the wrong animal.
- Asked what they wished was in the game: the people should flee from Dracula.

Session 3: Outside players

Date: 18 August 2026, submission day **Players:** two members of college staff with no connection to the game programme, one from Foundations and one from administration **Observer:** a team member, taking notes during play

Observation focus: whether players outside the programme, with no idea what the prototype was meant to demonstrate, could read the controls and the objective. These were the first players in the cycle who were not a teammate, a teammate's relative, or an instructor.

Player A, Foundations

- First instinct was to attack with the mouse.
- Read Z as a generic “magic button”.
- Mixed up X and Z repeatedly.
- Enjoys vampire fiction and wanted to see more of it in the game.
- Liked the music.
- Wanted the game darker.
- Suggested a change to the streetlamp design.
- Noted that players tend to keep whatever the default settings are.

Observer's reference note: Star Stable Online, as a keyboard layout reference.

Player B, Administration

- Figured out the controls quickly.

- Died and immediately replayed.
- Asked why the controls were not on the main menu.
- Did not want to enter bat form every time.
- General traversal confusion.
- Did not understand the objectives.
- The humour in the game's description is not present in the game itself.
- Wanted more basic movement.

Observer's reference note: Dracula: Dead and Loving It, as a tone reference.

What this session confirms

- “Did not understand the objectives” independently repeats the finding from 10 August, from a player with no connection to the first session. The objective has now failed to communicate to two unrelated players eight days apart.
- Control legibility is a distinct problem from traversal: one player learned the scheme quickly and still could not read the level, while the other could not hold the X and Z mapping at all.
- Immediate replay after death is the strongest positive signal in the record set.

Revisions driven by the 10 August sessions

Every change committed to the project after 10 August traces to one of the two sessions held that day. Dates are commit dates.

Observation	Revision	Date
Vampire spritesheet needs more frames; flight not always working; the Animation / VFX mockups	Falling animation, eating animation, NPC idle and death replaced in the game scene, bat animation pass	12 Aug
Got caught on the crocodile; alligator jump confusing, lunge attack may be on the wrong animal	Crocodile and kangaroo art produced and animated	13 Aug
Analogue controls delay in directional change; flying could be tighter	Cinemachine camera with lookahead added; camera deadzone tuned	13, 18 Aug
Chromatic aberration, colour correction, 2D spot lights, volumetrics, dedicated volume	Lighting prefabs and post-processing pass, then a second post-processing pass	15, 16 Aug
Reveal the tunnels; show a light for the tunnel; did not know he had to jump through buildings	Level design update to the game scene; dawn fade added; audio trigger frequency increased	16, 17 Aug

Observations the sessions found already addressed and still failing

Two items had shipped before 10 August and the session showed the underlying problem was not solved. These are recorded separately because they are the most useful records in the set: in both cases the group believed the issue was closed.

Observation on 10 Aug	What already existed	Built
Player did not understand the sightseeing objective; observer sketched a redesign of the counter	A “Sights to See” counter was already in the build	6 Aug
Vampire spritesheet needs more frames	Additional frames had already been added to the vampire animations	4 Aug

The sightseeing objective remained incompletely implemented at submission.

Recorded and not acted on

Observation	Decision
The people should flee from Dracula	Declined for this cycle. Recorded as a candidate for further development rather than built, on scope grounds.
Hard to die, may need to be more difficult	No difficulty change was made after 10 August. Not consciously declined; it was not picked up.
Clock not working	Clock wiring was committed on 10 August, the same day as the sessions. The order of the two cannot be established from the project history.

Coverage note: one observation day inside the three-week cycle, on 10 August, with both observers drawn from the group's immediate circle. The only session with players from outside the programme took place on submission day, too late to drive a revision. Both limitations are addressed in the individual reflection.